‘No one knows what discussion took place behind closed doors at Raisina Hill but I was told that the government had already decided to go ahead with the dealer’s offer of Rs 110 crore. Our asset was disappointed and com-

pletely withdrew. And we couldn’t say a word since we are not supposed to fix commercial deals on behalf of the government. But given a chance, we can do a better job than most of the agencies tasked with such activities. On this front, R&AW remains highly underutilised,’ a R&AW spy codenamed P. Narasimhan told me.

India had been doing a lot of defence shopping in the UK and the Soviet Union since Independence. The bureaucrats at Raisina Hill were the deciding factor, aside from the top brass of the defence forces. The Indian government bought Canberra jet bombers, trainers and reconnaissance aircraft from the British in the late 1950s. It had been a conscious decision not to become dependent on Soviet resources, although the USSR remained India’s major supplier. The US and the UK imposed an arms embargo on India during the 1965 war with Pakistan, forcing the Indian government to look to Moscow for fighters, helicopters, air defence missile systems, tanks, armoured vehicles, artillery, tactical air defence systems, destroyers and submarines. Unlike the Western countries, the Soviets were ready to sell modern weaponry systems on easy credit terms and in some cases, they did not demand hard currency, but allowed the Indian government to pay with commodities.

After Prime Minister Indira Gandhi’s government came to power, bureaucrats were sent to Paris to buy the Mirage 2000 as a counter to the F-16s provided to Pakistan by the USA. The CIA suggested that India’s purchases in the Western arms markets